

SEPTEMBER-NOVEMBER

Autumn in the garden

Gather the harvest. Care for the soil.
Make room for a slower season.

Practical notes for home gardeners
in temperate Central Europe.

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SEPTEMBER

Gather the last of the sunshine.

The garden is still giving. Pick what is ready, keep a little growing, and turn small harvests into everyday pleasures.



Pick gently, store wisely

Harvest ripe apples with a gentle lift and twist. Store only sound fruit in a cool, frost-free, airy place; use bruised fruit promptly and discard mouldy produce. Check stored crops regularly.

Keep a little green going

Early in the month, try small sowings of spinach, winter lettuce or rocket. Choose autumn varieties and follow packet dates. In colder or higher gardens, sow under protection or save late sowings for spring.

Plant a pocket of spring

Plant daffodils and crocuses early in autumn, in a well-drained spot or pot. Follow the packet for depth and spacing. A small cluster beside the door is enough to change a spring morning.

THIS MONTH

- ☐ Pick ripe fruit and late vegetables.
- ☐ Sow a small row of autumn leaves.
- ☐ Weed before seed heads scatter.
- ☐ Check pot moisture 2-3 cm down.
- ☐ Find the fleece before frost arrives.

Let the weather lead

These months are a guide. Frost dates vary with altitude and exposure. Use local forecasts; move frost-sensitive crops and pots into shelter before cold nights.

Field notes: RHS September tasks and bulb planting. Linked reading on page 5.

OCTOBER

Build next season from the soil up.

A little work now becomes a quieter spring. Feed empty beds, plant garlic, and let fallen leaves start their slow transformation.

ONE SATISFYING JOB

Plant your garlic

Choose healthy planting garlic from a reputable supplier, with a variety suited to your winter. A sunny, well-drained bed gives cloves the best start.

- 1 Split the bulb just before planting; keep the papery skin on each clove.
- 2 Set cloves pointed end up, about 15 cm apart, in rows 30 cm apart. Put the tip roughly 2.5 cm below the soil; follow local supplier advice for colder sites.
- 3 Label the variety and date. In heavy, wet soil, start in modules in a ventilated cold frame and plant out in spring.



A small clove, a long promise.

Cover the soil

Clear finished annual crops and remove weeds. Spread a layer of well-rotted compost over empty beds; keep it clear of plant crowns and woody stems. Work from paths when soil is wet.

October checklist

- ☐ Plant and label garlic.
- ☐ Mulch one cleared bed.
- ☐ Check stored fruit for rot.

SLOW GARDENING

Leaves are future soil

Gather fallen leaves from paths and lawns. Moisten dry leaves, then pack into a ventilated leaf bin or a reused bag with air holes. Keep damp and leave to decay, usually for around two years. The result is lovely leafmould for mulching.

Field notes: RHS October tasks, garlic and leafmould. Linked reading on page 5.

NOVEMBER

Put the garden gently to bed.

The season slows, but the garden still has life in it.

Protect what needs shelter and leave a little room for wildlife.



01 / PROTECT

Shelter the tender

Move frost-tender pots to a bright, frost-free place suited to the plant. Insulate containers and keep drainage holes open. Fleece helps with light frost; it cannot make a tender plant winter-hardy.

02 / PLANT

A start for spring

Plant bare-root fruit trees and bushes while dormant, only if the soil is workable and not frozen or waterlogged. November is also a good time for tulip bulbs; use the packet depth and a well-drained position.

03 / LEAVE

Keep a wild corner

Leave healthy seedheads and some standing stems for birds and sheltering insects. Tuck a few logs and leaves into a quiet corner. Remove diseased plant material and keep wet leaves off busy paths.

BEFORE YOU HANG UP YOUR GLOVES

- ☐ Check covers, ties and drainage.
- ☐ Brush soil from tools; dry and store.
- ☐ Clear leaves from paths and lawns.
- ☐ Plant only into workable soil.
- ☐ Check stored fruit and vegetables.
- ☐ Note one success to repeat next year.

Field notes: RHS November tasks, bulbs and plant protection; RSPB seedheads. Reading on page 5.

THE AUTUMN KITCHEN

Bring the season indoors.

A warm bowl, a simple pudding, a little saved for later.



SUPPER / SERVES 4 / ABOUT 50 MIN

Roasted pumpkin & thyme soup

You need 800 g peeled, deseeded cooking pumpkin or squash, cubed; 1 onion, sliced; 2 peeled garlic cloves; 2 tbsp olive oil; 750 ml vegetable stock; 1 tsp thyme leaves; salt and pepper.

1. Heat the oven to 200°C (180°C fan). Toss pumpkin, onion and garlic with the oil. Roast on a tray for 30-35 minutes, until tender and golden.
2. Transfer to a pan with stock and thyme. Simmer for 10 minutes, then blend carefully until smooth. Add a little water if needed and season to taste.
3. Serve with bread, fresh thyme and a drizzle of olive oil.

SOMETHING SWEET

Warm baked apples

Serves 2 / 35-45 min

Halve and core 2 apples. Mix 2 tbsp oats, 1 tbsp raisins, 1 tbsp brown sugar and ½ tsp cinnamon; spoon into the centres.

Set in a baking dish. Dot with 10 g butter; add 3 tbsp water. Bake at 180°C (160°C fan) for 25-35 minutes, until tender. Serve with the juices.

SAVE A LITTLE FOR LATER

Herb cubes: wash and chop parsley; freeze in an ice-cube tray with water, then bag and label. **Extra soup:** divide into shallow containers; refrigerate within 2 hours at 4°C or below. Eat within 3-4 days or freeze promptly. Thaw in the fridge; reheat to 74°C, bringing soup to a rolling boil.

A little plan goes a long way. Keep your autumn notes with CozyGrow Garden.

cozygrowgarden.com

RHS: Sep tasks Oct tasks Nov tasks Garlic Leafmould Bulbs
Winter protection RSPB: seedheads FoodSafety.gov USDA: leftovers

FROM GARDEN TO TABLE

Ajvar, a spoonful of late summer.

Sweet roasted peppers, a little aubergine, and a slow simmer.
A small batch to eat now or freeze for colder days.



MAKES ABOUT 600 G / ALLOW 2 HOURS

You need 900 g red sweet peppers; 1 small aubergine (about 300 g); 4 tbsp sunflower oil; 2 garlic cloves, finely chopped; 2 tbsp white wine vinegar; ½ tsp salt, then more to taste. Optional: a pinch of chilli flakes.

Roast, peel, simmer

1. Heat the oven to 220°C (200°C fan). Halve and deseed the peppers; roast skin-side up. Halve the aubergine and place cut-side down alongside. Roast for 35-45 minutes, until soft and the pepper skins blister.
2. Cover the peppers for 10 minutes, then peel when cool enough to handle. Scoop out the aubergine flesh. Drain both in a sieve for 15 minutes, then finely chop or pulse briefly.
3. Warm the oil in a wide pan. Add the vegetables, garlic, vinegar and salt. Simmer gently for 30-45 minutes, stirring often, until thick enough to spread. Taste and adjust the seasoning; add chilli if you like.

A LITTLE SAVED

Save safely

Divide into clean, shallow containers and refrigerate within 2 hours at 4°C or below. Use within 3-4 days. Freeze extra portions for up to 3 months for best quality; thaw in the fridge.

This is a fridge/freezer recipe, not a shelf-stable canning method.

On the table

Spread on toast, tuck into sandwiches, or serve with roasted vegetables and warm flatbread.

Recipe approach: Luca Marchiori / Great Italian Chefs. Storage: USDA leftovers guidance.

YOUR PRINTABLE GARDEN COMPANION

My autumn garden week.

Choose a few useful jobs, make room for the weather, and note what grows.
Print and write, or fill this page in your PDF reader. Use a fresh copy each week.

WEEK STARTING

MONTH

GARDEN / SPACE

FORECAST / FROST RISK

MY FOCUS

☐ Harvest

☐ Plant

☐ Soil care

☐ Protect

THIS WEEK'S TASKS

H = High

M = Medium

L = Low

DONE	TASK	PLANT / SPACE	DUE DATE	H/M/L
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				

Harvest notes

PLANT / CROP

AMOUNT

DATE

Garden journal

What worked? What needs attention?

Shopping list

☐

☐

Next week, remember...

Inspired by CozyGrow Garden's task, journal and shopping tools. Explore more at cozygrowgarden.com.